

WEEK 19

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 4: 38 – 44; 6: 1 – 7*

The miracles of Elisha for the sons of the prophets.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

And Eli'sha came again to Gilgal when there was a famine in the land. And as the sons of the prophets were sitting before him, he said to his servant, "Set on the great pot, and boil pottage for the sons of the prophets." One of them went out into the field to gather herbs, and found a wild vine and gathered from it his lap full of wild gourds, and came and cut them up into the pot of pottage, not knowing what they were. And they poured out for the men to eat. But while they were eating of the pottage, they cried out, "O man of God, there is death in the pot!" And they could not eat it. He said, "Then bring meal." And he threw it into the pot, and said, "Pour out for the men, that they may eat." And there was no harm in the pot.

A man came from Ba'al-shal'ishah, bringing the man of God bread of the first fruits, twenty loaves of barley, and fresh ears of grain in his sack. And Eli'sha said, "Give to the men, that they may eat." But his servant said, "How am I to set this before a hundred men?" So he repeated, "Give them to the men, that they may eat, for thus says the LORD, 'They shall eat and have some left.'" So he set it before them. And they ate, and had some left, according to the word of the LORD. Now the sons of the prophets said to Eli'sha, "See, the place where we dwell under your charge is too small for us. Let us go to the Jordan and each of us get there a log, and let us make a place for us to dwell there." And he answered, "Go." Then one of them said, "Be pleased to go with your servants." And he answered, "I will go." So he went with them. And when they came to the Jordan, they cut down trees. But as one was felling a log, his axe head fell into the water; and he cried out, "Alas, my master! It was borrowed." Then the man of God said, "Where did it fall?" When he showed him the place, he cut off a stick, and threw it in there, and made the iron float. And he said, "Take it up." So he reached out his hand and took it.

Responsorial. *Sir. 2, 13. 15; Jn. 4, 48*

R: Woe to the lazy heart because it does not have faith; for this it will not be protected; * those who fear the Lord do not disobey His words.

V: If you do not see signs and prodigies, you do not believe.

R: those who fear the Lord do not disobey His words.

Second Reading. *Book 5: 17, 3 – 4*

The economy of the cross has revealed to us the hidden Word.

A reading from the treatise “Against the heresies” of St. Irenaeus, bishop.

“Blessed is the man to whom the Lord imputes no evil” (Ps. 31, 21) showing in precedence that remission that is realised with His coming, remission thanks to which is annulled “the written document of our debt, nailing it to the cross” (Col. 2, 14); in a way that, as through a piece of wood we had become debtors of God, so also by means of a piece of wood we have received the remission of our debt.

This is shown in a significant way also by means of many others, as already also through the prophet Elisha. While in fact the prophets who were with him cut the wood to construct the tabernacle, the blade of the axe detached itself and fell into the Jordan, and they were unable to find it again, Elisha having arrived and having heard of what had happened, threw a piece of wood into the water; as soon as he had done this, the iron of the axe floated up to the surface and from there those who had lost it were able to recover it. In this way the prophet showed that the solid Word of God, lost by us through negligence because of a piece of wood, and which we were not capable of finding anymore, we would newly receive by means of a piece of wood.

The Word of God is truly similar to an axe, and of it John the Baptist says: “Already the axe has been placed to the roots of the trees” (Mt. 3, 10). Similarly Jeremiah says: The word of God is “like a hammer that breaks the rock” (Jer. 23, 29).

Therefore as we have said, it was actually a piece of wood that revealed to us again the Word that was hidden to us. As in fact we had lost him because of a piece of wood, so also through a piece of wood He was revealed to all, showing in himself the height, the length and the breadth; as

one of the apostles says, he reconciled to only one God the two peoples by stretching His arms (cfr. Ep. 2, 16); two were the hands, and two were the people who were dispersed up to the extreme boundaries of the earth; But one only was the head that reunited them, because “ there is only one God, who is above all, who acts through all and is present in all” (Ep. 4, 6).

Responsorial. *Cfr. Ws. 14, 5. 7; 1 Pt. 2, 24*

R: Men trust their life even to a small piece of wood. * Blessed is the wood that produces justice.

V: He carried our sins in His body on the wood of the cross.

R: Blessed is the wood that produces justice

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jon. 1: 1 – 2:1,11*

Vocation, flight and shipwreck of Jonah.

A reading from the prophet Jonah.

Now the word of the LORD came to Jonah the son of Amit'tai, saying, "Arise, go to Nin'evah, that great city, and cry against it; for their wickedness has come up before me." But Jonah rose to flee to Tarshish from the presence of the LORD. He went down to Joppa and found a ship going to Tarshish; so he paid the fare, and went on board, to go with them to Tarshish, away from the presence of the LORD.

But the LORD hurled a great wind upon the sea, and there was a mighty tempest on the sea, so that the ship threatened to break up. Then the mariners were afraid, and each cried to his god; and they threw the wares that were in the ship into the sea, to lighten it for them. But Jonah had gone down into the inner part of the ship and had lain down, and was fast asleep.

So the captain came and said to him, "What do you mean, you sleeper? Arise, call upon your god! Perhaps the god will give a thought to us, that we do not perish." And they said to one another, "Come, let us cast lots, that we may know on whose account this evil has come upon us."

So they cast lots, and the lot fell upon Jonah. Then they said to him, "Tell us, on whose account this evil has come upon us? What is your occupation? And whence do you come? What is your country? And of what

people are you?" And he said to them, "I am a Hebrew; and I fear the LORD, the God of heaven, who made the sea and the dry land." Then the men were exceedingly afraid, and said to him, "What is this that you have done!" For the men knew that he was fleeing from the presence of the LORD, because he had told them. Then they said to him, "What shall we do to you, that the sea may quiet down for us?" For the sea grew more and more tempestuous. He said to them, "Take me up and throw me into the sea; then the sea will quiet down for you; for I know it is because of me that this great tempest has come upon you." Nevertheless the men rowed hard to bring the ship back to land, but they could not, for the sea grew more and more tempestuous against them.

Therefore they cried to the LORD, "We beseech you, O LORD, let us not perish for this man's life, and lay not on us innocent blood; for you, O LORD, have done as it pleased you." So they took up Jonah and threw him into the sea; and the sea ceased from its raging. Then the men feared the LORD exceedingly, and they offered a sacrifice to the LORD and made vows.

And the LORD appointed a great fish to swallow up Jonah; and Jonah was in the belly of the fish three days and three nights. Then Jonah prayed to the LORD his God from the belly of the fish, and the LORD spoke to the fish, and it vomited out Jonah upon the dry land.

Responsorial. *Jon. 1, 1- 3; Mt. 12, 39*

R: This word of the Lord was addressed to Jonah: "Get up, go to Nineveh the great city and proclaim in it: * their wickedness has risen up to me".

V: A perverse and adulterous generation asks for a sign! But no sign will be given to it, if not the sign of the prophet Jonah:

R: their wickedness has risen up to me.

Second Reading. *Ps. 43, 83 – 85*

The sign of Jonah.

A reading from the "Commentary on the Psalms" of St. Ambrose, bishop.

Let us examine if what we read in Jonah is far away from the Gospel; that is that he was sleeping profoundly in the bottom of the boat: a pre-figuration of the holy passion. As in fact Jonah was sleeping in the boat and

snoring tranquilly, without fear of being captured, so also Our Lord Jesus Christ, who fulfils that pre-figuration with the mystery of His death, at the time of the preaching of the Gospel slept in the boat; and as Jonah had “remained three days and three nights in the belly of the fish, so also the Son of man remained three days and three nights in the heart of the earth” (Mt, 12, 40) during His passion. When He awoke from death, reawakening His body from sleep, He arose for the universal salvation and visited his disciples.

He, therefore is the true Jonah, who gives His life to redeem us. He had been taken and thrown into the sea because, captured and devoured by the whale, He could purify her living inside her. Of which whale are we referring to, listen to Job: “Am I perhaps a sea monster, so that you have to capture me?” (Jb. 7, 12)

Who is this one? You know Him when you read that our Lord Jesus Christ “ascending into heaven took with Him prisoners” (Ep. 4, 8). The enemy in fact having been defeated, we who were slaves have started to possess through Christ, freedom. Besides this the same plea of the holy Jonah teaches us that it is dealing with the mysteries of the passion of the Lord; in fact he says “In my anguish I invoked the Lord and He listened to me; from the depths of hell I cried” (Joh. 2, 3). Do you see that he speaks of the depths of hell, not of the whale? The Lord in fact descended not into the whale, but into hell in order to liberate from prison also those who were found there.

Who is it who fulfils the sacrifice praising and confessing the Lord, if not the first of all the priests, who prayed and implored for everyone? He alone could obtain a similar result. When Jonah was thrown into the sea, the sea became calm; so also our Lord Jesus Christ came into this world in order to save it, reconciling every thing with His blood, both in heaven and on earth (Cfr. Col. 1, 20). With His coming He redeemed all of humanity and with His works, raising the dead, curing the sick, infusing into the hearts of men the fear of God, He brought them to adore Him. He is the one who offers for us to God a sacrifice of salvation, offering a victim that is worthy for our conversion; He is the one who after having slept has awakened forever.

Responsorial. *Mt. 12, 40; 20, 19; Joh. 2, 2. 11*

R: As Jonah remained three days and three nights in the belly of the fish, * so also the Son of man will remain three days and three nights in the heart of the earth, but the third day He will rise again.

V: From the belly of the fish Jonah prayed to the Lord his God; and the Lord commanded the fish and it vomited Jonah onto the dry ground.

R: So also the Son of man will remain three days and three nights in the heart of the earth, but the third day He will rise again.

YEAR A

Gospel. *Mt. 14: 22-33*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Then he made the disciples get into the boat and go before him to the other side, while he dismissed the crowds. And after he had dismissed the crowds, he went up on the mountain by himself to pray. When evening came, he was there alone, but the boat by this time was many furlongs distant from the land, beaten by the waves; for the wind was against them. And in the fourth watch of the night he came to them, walking on the sea. But when the disciples saw him walking on the sea, they were terrified, saying, "It is a ghost!" And they cried out for fear. But immediately he spoke to them, saying, "Take heart, it is I; have no fear." And Peter answered him, "Lord, if it is you, bid me come to you on the water." He said, "Come." So Peter got out of the boat and walked on the water and came to Jesus; but when he saw the wind, he was afraid, and beginning to sink he cried out, "Lord, save me." Jesus immediately reached out his hand and caught him, saying to him, "O man of little faith, why did you doubt?" And when they got into the boat, the wind ceased. And those in the boat worshiped him, saying, "Truly you are the Son of God."

Third Reading. *Disc. 76: 1, 4, 5, 6, 8, 9*

Lord, I am lost: save me!

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Augustine, bishop.

The gospel that has been read speaks of Christ the Lord who walked on the water of the sea and of the apostle Peter who while walking on the water hesitated because of fear; and mistrusting sank, but when he had found trust again he re-emerged. This reminds us that the sea is the world and Peter is the symbol of the only Church. The same Peter in fact, first in the order of the apostles, very generous in love towards Christ, often answered, he alone, in the name of everyone. When the Lord Jesus Christ asked them who men said he was, while the disciples put forward the various opinions of the people, to the repeated question of the Lord “And you, who do you say I am?” (Mk. 8: 29), it was Peter who answered: “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God” (Mt. 16: 16). He alone answers in the name of the others, expressing in this way the unity.

Contemplating this member of the Church, we distinguish in him that which is of God from that which is ours. In this way we learn not to be doubtful, but we base ourselves on the rock, unmoveable and constant against the winds, rain and rivers, that is against the temptations of this world. Observe therefore Peter, who then was the figure of all of us: now he trusts, now doubts, now he considers himself immortal, now he is afraid of dying. Since the Church of Christ is formed by the strong and by the weak, it is inevitable that there is one and the other.

That which Peter proclaimed: “You are the Christ of God”, shows the behaviour of the strong; when instead he is afraid and hesitates, fears death not recognising the life, and desiring that the Christ should not suffer, he symbolises the weak who form a part of the Church.

This is the meaning of what has been read until now: “Lord, if it is you, command that I come to you over the water” (Mt 14: 28). Peter walked over the water at the command of the Lord, knowing well that he would not have been able to do so with his own strength. Through faith he fulfilled that which human weakness could not do. These are the strong ones of the Church. The Man-God commanded and the man was able to fulfil the impossible. “Come!” (Mt. 14: 29) he said and “getting out of the boat, he began to walk over the water”. Peter could do it, because he who is the Rock had commanded it. This is what Peter became in the Lord; and what is he in himself? “But because of the violence of the wind he became afraid and, beginning to sink, he cried out: Lord, save me!” (Mt. 14: 30). When he trusted in the Lord, he had strength from him. When as a man he became

anxious, he turned again to the Lord, and he, offering immediately the help of his right hand, caught him while he was sinking, rebuking him for his diffidence: "Man of little faith!" (Mt. 14: 31).

Let us conclude, brothers. Consider that the world is like the sea: violent wind, furious tempest. For each one his passions are a tempest. If you love God, you walk on the water and the fury of the world is under your feet. If you love the world, it will overwhelm you: it in fact knows how to devour those who love it, not to sustain them. But when your heart is agitated by the passions, invoke the divinity of Christ in order to overcome them. And if your foot wavers, if you doubt, if you are not able to overcome something, if you begin to sink, exclaim: "Lord, save me!" (Mt. 14: 30).

Only he in fact frees you from the death of the flesh, he who in his flesh has died for you.

Responsorial. *Ps. 15: 8, 9, 1-2*

R: The Lord is at my right hand, I cannot waver. * For this my heart rejoices, my soul exults.

V: Protect me, O God: in you I take refuge. I have said to God: "You are my Lord".

R: For this my heart rejoices, my soul exults.

YEAR B

Gospel. *Jn. 6: 41-51*

A reading from the Gospel of St. John.

The Jews then murmured at him, because he said, "I am the bread that came down from heaven." They said, "Is not this Jesus, the son of Joseph, whose father and mother we know? How does he now say, 'I have come down from heaven'?"

Jesus answered them, "Do not murmur among yourselves. No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him; and I will raise him up at the last day. It is written in the prophets, 'And they shall all be taught by God.' Every one who has heard and learned from the Father comes to me. Not that any one has seen the Father except him who is from God; he

has seen the Father. Truly, truly, I say to you, he who believes has eternal life. I am the bread of life. Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died. This is the bread that comes down from heaven, that a man may eat of it and not die. I am the living bread which came down from heaven; if any one eats of this bread, he will live for ever; and the bread which I shall give for the life of the world is my flesh."

Third Reading. Book. 6: 51-52

The bread that I will give is my flesh for the life of the world.

A reading from the "Commentary on the Gospel of John" of Rupert of Deutz, abbot.

"I am the bread that has come down from heaven. If anyone eats of this bread he will live forever" (Jn. 6: 51). Since the guests of my Father were destroyed by death because of the prohibited food that their parents had eaten, and their souls are in hell, the bodies instead in the tombs, I also who am the bread of angels will be destroyed. And with that substance of which the angels are nourished I will descend into the underworld, where the souls are hungry, while with the body I will rest hidden for three days and three nights in the same womb of the earth in which their bodies are buried, as Jonah remained three days and three nights in the belly of the sea mammal. In this way their souls will be recreated in the sight of God and many bodies will rise now; all the others certainly in the future.

Finally, to those who are still in the body down here, this same bread will be offered in a way that is suitable to the living, that is in the true sacrifice of the bread and wine according to the order of Melchizedek.

"And the bread that I will give is my flesh for the life of the world" (Jn. 6: 51). This is the greatest consolation for the poor, that the Holy Spirit descending on me sends me to evangelise; this will be the greatest and incomparable motive of joy for all the nations spread over the earth, who will ask and will receive from the Father in possession and inheritance. And those to whom the Father has sent me will not have less than the ancient fathers of this bread of life that he has given and on whom "he has put his seal" (Jn. 6: 44, 27). In fact, when I will have descended to them to fill them with myself, after hell had stung me and I had become its sting and the death of death which it enclosed in its bowels, and I had reached the starving saints and just men in order to give life back to them: then I will

give to those who have remained that bread, in which the reality of my own flesh is present, that is that body which, having come out of the belly of the sea mammal, healthy and complete will reside eternally at the right hand of the Father. The man who is still living will feed in a way that is to him in keeping with the same bread of angels which I will give to him, and which the Father gives to those who are not anymore of this earth so that they may eat it and rise, now with the soul, and on the last day also with the body.

“And the bread that I will give is my flesh for the life of the world” (Jn. 6: 51), and truly the Father gives the bread of angels so that he could take a body and he could die in order to give life to the dead. This same heavenly bread gives us an earthly bread that transforms into his flesh, in order to give eternal life to the living who can eat it. And so the Word, who is the bread of angels, became flesh, not changing himself into flesh, but assuming a body; so also the same Word already made flesh becomes visible bread, not because he is changed into bread but because he assumes and transfers the bread into the unity of his person. As a consequence, as through the unity of the person we recognise the true God in our flesh generated by the Virgin Mary, so also we confess with full and catholic faith that this visible bread, assumed and transformed by the invisible divinity of the Word in his flesh, is truly the Body of Christ. In fact he says: “The bread that I will give is my flesh for the life of the world” (Jn. 6: 51), that is because the redeemed world eats and lives, after having washed in baptism that original sin committed with the ancient food that the serpent gave and induced to eat.

Responsorial. *Jn. 6: 56; Deut. 4: 7*

R: He who eats my flesh and drinks my blood, * lives in me and I in him.

V: What great nation has its divinity so close to itself, as the Lord your God is close to you? **R:** Lives in me and I in him.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 12: 32-48*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

"Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father's good pleasure to give you the kingdom. Sell your possessions, and give alms; provide yourselves with

purses that do not grow old, with a treasure in the heavens that does not fail, where no thief approaches and no moth destroys. For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also. "Let your loins be girded and your lamps burning, and be like men who are waiting for their master to come home from the marriage feast, so that they may open to him at once when he comes and knocks. Blessed are those servants whom the master finds awake when he comes; truly, I say to you, he will gird himself and have them sit at table, and he will come and serve them. If he comes in the second watch, or in the third, and finds them so, blessed are those servants! But know this, that if the householder had known at what hour the thief was coming, he would not have left his house to be broken into. You also must be ready; for the Son of man is coming at an unexpected hour."

Peter said, "Lord, are you telling this parable for us or for all?" And the Lord said, "Who then is the faithful and wise steward, whom his master will set over his household, to give them their portion of food at the proper time? Blessed is that servant whom his master when he comes will find so doing. Truly, I say to you, he will set him over all his possessions. But if that servant says to himself, 'My master is delayed in coming,' and begins to beat the menservants and the maidservants, and to eat and drink and get drunk, the master of that servant will come on a day when he does not expect him and at an hour he does not know, and will punish him, and put him with the unfaithful. And that servant who knew his master's will, but did not make ready or act according to his will, shall receive a severe beating. But he who did not know, and did what deserved a beating, shall receive a light beating. Every one to whom much is given, of him will much be required; and of him to whom men commit much they will demand the more.

Third Reading. *Disc. 15: 11-13*

The word of God is the light for my steps.

A reading from the "Commentary on Psalm 118" of St. Ambrose, bishop

The faith will accompany you on the way, the divine Scripture will be your road. The Word of God is a good guide. Light up your light to this lamp, so that your interior eye, which is the lamp of your body, will be illuminated. You have many lamps: light them all up because it has been

said to you: “See that you are dressed for action and have your lamps lit” (Lk. 12: 35). Where the darkness is great, many lamps are necessary and in much darkness the light of our merits must shine forth. These are the lamps that the law has established to shine continuously in the tabernacle of the testimony. It represents our body, in which Christ came, who “through a greater and more perfect tent, entered once and for all into the sanctuary with his own blood” (Heb. 9: 11, 12) in order to purify our soul from all works of death and from every stain. Now in our bodies, which with the quality of their actions manifest our hidden thoughts, must always shine the clear light of our virtues like as many lamps. These are the burning lamps that shine day and night in the temple of God. If you keep your body as the temple of God, if your members are the members of Christ, your virtues shine with the clear light and no one, other than your sin, can put it off. Of this light of pure minds and sincere affections shines our solemnities.

Therefore let your lamp always shine. The Christ rebukes also those who, though possessing the lamp, do not keep it always lit, saying: “See that you are dressed for action and have your lamps lit” (Lk. 12: 35). We must not enjoy only for a short time of this light. He enjoys only for a short time the one who, after having listened to the word in the Church and having rejoiced, as soon as he goes out forgets everything and does not care. This one walks in his house without light, since he is in the darkness and does works of darkness, clothed with the clothes of the devil, not of Christ. This is what happens when the lamp of the world is not lit. Let us never neglect the word of the Lord, which is for us the source of every virtue and progress of all our works.

If the members of the body cannot work well without the light- the feet in fact are uncertain and the hands make mistakes-, how much more must the steps of the soul and the operations of our mind be illuminated by the light of the Word. As Thomas touched the signs of the resurrection of the Lord, so also in the light of the word the hands of the soul do not err. This lamp remains lit in every word and in every work. All our interior and external steps are directed towards it.

Responsorial. *Ps. 118: 104, 105; Jn. 6: 68*

R: I hate all deceptive paths. * Your word is a lamp to my feet, a light on my path.

V: Lord, to whom shall we go? You have words of eternal life.

R: Your word is a lamp to my feet, a light on my path.

MONDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 5: 1 – 19*

Elisha reveals the power of God on Naaman the Syrian.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

Naaman, commander of the army of the king of Syria, was a great man with his master and in high favour, because by him the LORD had given victory to Syria. He was a mighty man of valour, but he was a leper. Now the Syrians on one of their raids had carried off a little maid from the land of Israel, and she waited on Naaman's wife. She said to her mistress, "Would that my lord were with the prophet who is in Samaria! He would cure him of his leprosy." So Na'aman went in and told his lord, "Thus and so spoke the maiden from the land of Israel." And the king of Syria said, "Go now, and I will send a letter to the king of Israel." So he went, taking with him ten talents of silver, six thousand shekels of gold, and ten festal garments. And he brought the letter to the king of Israel, which read, "When this letter reaches you, know that I have sent to you Na'aman my servant, that you may cure him of his leprosy." And when the king of Israel read the letter, he rent his clothes and said, "Am I God, to kill and to make alive, that this man sends word to me to cure a man of his leprosy? Only consider, and see how he is seeking a quarrel with me."

But when Eli'sha the man of God heard that the king of Israel had rent his clothes, he sent to the king, saying, "Why have you rent your clothes? Let him come now to me, that he may know that there is a prophet in Israel." So Na'aman came with his horses and chariots, and halted at the door of Eli'sha's house. And Eli'sha sent a messenger to him, saying, "Go and wash in the Jordan seven times, and your flesh shall be restored, and you shall be clean." But Na'aman was angry, and went away, saying, "Behold, I thought that he would surely come out to me, and stand, and call on the name of the LORD his God, and wave his hand over the place, and cure the leper. Are not Aba'na and Pharpar, the rivers of Damascus, better than all the waters of Israel? Could I not wash in them, and be clean?" So he turned and went away in a rage.

But his servants came near and said to him, "My father, if the prophet had commanded you to do some great thing, would you not have done it? How much rather, then, when he says to you, 'Wash, and be clean'?" So he went down and dipped himself seven times in the Jordan, according to the word of the man of God; and his flesh was restored like the flesh of a little child, and he was clean.

Then he returned to the man of God, he and all his company, and he came and stood before him; and he said, "Behold, I know that there is no God in all the earth but in Israel; so accept now a present from your servant." But he said, "As the LORD lives, whom I serve, I will receive none." And he urged him to take it, but he refused. Then Na'aman said, "If not, I pray you, let there be given to your servant two mules' burden of earth; for henceforth your servant will not offer burnt offering or sacrifice to any god but the LORD. In this matter may the LORD pardon your servant: when my master goes into the house of Rimmon to worship there, leaning on my arm, and I bow myself in the house of Rimmon, when I bow myself in the house of Rimmon, the LORD pardon your servant in this matter." He said to him, "Go in peace."

Responsorial. *2 Kg. 5, 14. 15; Lk. 4, 27*

R: The flesh of the leper became like the flesh of a young boy; he was cured. * And Naaman said: "There is no other God in all the earth but in Israel".

V: there were many lepers in Israel at the time of the prophet Elisha, but none of them were cured but Naaman, the Syrian.

R: And Naaman said: "There is no other God in all the earth but in Israel.

Second Reading. *Disc. 13:1 – 4*

We have drawn from the same spring from which Christ drew, in order to be that which Christ is.

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Maximus of Turin, bishop.

It is evident that the baptism of Jesus Christ did not happen for him but for us. Thus my dear brothers we have to hurry to receive the grace of his baptism, drawing from the source of the Jordan, made sacred by Him, the

grace of that same consecration, so that in that wave in which His holiness was immersed our sins too may be immersed. The same water that touched and surrounded the Lord, purifies also the servants; that holy wave that flows from the venerable bath of Christ is useful to us, and through the effect of that sacred presence with which the Saviour enriched it with grace, it purifies us with the saving action, pouring out on the Christians the grace received from Christ.

For this, brothers, we have to draw from that same source from which Christ drew, in order to be that which Christ is. In fact, remaining strong in faith, I would say, even though both being the baptisms of the Lord, yet I consider richer in grace this baptism in which we are purified, than that which the Saviour received. This is administered by Christ Himself, that by John; in that the Master justifies Himself, in this the Saviour calls all of us to salvation; in that justice has not yet been brought to its fulfilment, in this the Trinity is complete; and in that one who is already holy draws near and comes out holy, to this instead there comes one who is a sinner in order to come out holy; in that the mysteries of redemption itself are blessed, in this by means of the sacrament sins are forgiven.

Therefore, brothers, we have to be baptised in the same water in which the Saviour was baptised. But in order to immerse ourselves in this font, it is not necessary to go in search of the oriental land and the river Jordan; in fact now Christ is in every place, therefore even the Jordan is everywhere, the same grace that consecrated the rivers of the East sanctifies the rivers of the West. Therefore, even though the names of the rivers are different in time, yet in them the mystery that flows out from the Jordan is present in them.

Let us fulfil therefore in ourselves that which the Lord wanted to do for us! Let us draw near to receive that which John desired so much for himself! If he who was prophet, master and saint desired intensely the baptism of the Lord, how much more we, poor and ignorant sinners, should desire this grace? Consider the mercy of the Saviour: to us is offered spontaneously that which the prophet, who asked for it, could not receive! But we have to ask ourselves what was the reason for which John could not receive the baptism of Christ, which he had asked for. To his question the Lord answers: "Let it be for now, because it is necessary that in this way every justice is fulfilled" (Mt. 3, 15). We know that John the Baptist was the bearer of the type of the Law. It was therefore just, that it was he who

baptised the Lord, because, as the Saviour was born of the Jews according to the flesh, so also from the law the Gospel according to the Spirit had to be born; so that also the consecration could be transmitted from where the human origin drew itself. This is what he means when he says: "It is better that in this way we fulfil all justice" (Mt. 3, 15). He Himself, in fact had to fulfil the precepts of the law that He had established, as it says elsewhere: "I have not come to abolish, but to fulfil." (Mt. 5, 17).

Responsorial. *Gal. 3, 26 – 27; 1 Cor. 6, 15*

R: All of you are sons of God by the faith in Christ Jesus; * because all those of you who have been baptised in Christ, have been re-vested with Christ.

V: Your bodies are members of Christ;

R: because all those of you who have been baptised in Christ, have been re-vested with Christ.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jon. 3: 1 – 4:11*

Conversion of Nineveh and the lament of Jonah against God.

A reading from the prophet Jonah.

Then the word of the LORD came to Jonah the second time, saying, "Arise, go to Nin'evah, that great city, and proclaim to it the message that I tell you." So Jonah arose and went to Nin'evah, according to the word of the LORD. Now Nin'evah was an exceedingly great city, three days' journey in breadth. Jonah began to go into the city, going a day's journey. And he cried, "Yet forty days, and Nin'evah shall be overthrown!"

And the people of Nin'evah believed God; they proclaimed a fast, and put on sackcloth, from the greatest of them to the least of them. Then tidings reached the king of Nin'evah, and he arose from his throne, removed his robe, and covered himself with sackcloth, and sat in ashes. And he made proclamation and published through Nin'evah, "By the decree of the king and his nobles: Let neither man nor beast, herd nor flock, taste anything; let them not feed, or drink water. Let man and beast be covered with sackcloth, and let them cry mightily to God; yea, let every one turn from his evil way

and from the violence which is in his hands. Who knows, God may yet repent and turn from his fierce anger, so that we perish not?" When God saw what they did, how they turned from their evil way, God repented of the evil that he had said he would do to them; and he did not do it.

But it displeased Jonah exceedingly, and he was angry. And he prayed to the LORD and said, "I pray you, LORD, is not this what I said when I was yet in my country? That is why I made haste to flee to Tarshish; for I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love, and repenting of evil. Therefore now, O LORD, take my life from me, I beseech you, for it is better for me to die than to live." And the LORD said, "Do you do well to be angry?"

Then Jonah went out of the city and sat to the east of the city, and made a booth for himself there. He sat under it in the shade, till he should see what would become of the city. And the LORD God appointed a plant, and made it come up over Jonah, that it might be a shade over his head, to save him from his discomfort. So Jonah was exceedingly glad because of the plant.

But when dawn came up the next day, God appointed a worm that attacked the plant, so that it withered. When the sun rose, God appointed a sultry east wind, and the sun beat upon the head of Jonah so that he was faint; and he asked that he might die, and said, "It is better for me to die than to live."

But God said to Jonah, "Do you do well to be angry for the plant?" And he said, "I do well to be angry, angry enough to die." And the LORD said, "You pity the plant, for which you did not labour, nor did you make it grow, which came into being in a night, and perished in a night. And should not I pity Nin'evah, that great city, in which there are more than a hundred and twenty thousand persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also much cattle?"

Responsorial. *Mt. 12, 41; Jn. 3, 5. 10*

R: Those of Nineveh will arise to judge this generation and will condemn it, *because they converted at the preaching of Jonah.

V: They believed God, vested in sack - cloth and converted from their wicked conduct. **R:** because they converted at the preaching of Jonah.

Second Reading. Cc. 3:23 – 4:29

The Lord is ready to be merciful and saves those who do penance.

A reading from the “Commentary on the prophet Jonah” of St. Cyril of Alexandria, bishop.

“God saw their works, that is that they had converted from their wicked conduct” (Jon. 3, 10).

The Lord is merciful and saves the one who does penance, forgives immediately the ancient sins and, when men stop sinning, He stops getting angry and provides better things. And since He sees the soul dedicated to good resolutions, He reveals Himself as gentle, removes the damnation and concedes forgiveness. In fact the Truth says: “Why do you want to die, O Israelites? I do not take pleasure in the death of him who dies, but that the wicked desists from his conduct and lives” (Ez. 18, 31; 33, 11).

When He speaks instead of the evil that He has threatened (cfr. Jon. 3, 10), be careful not to think of wickedness, but rather of anger, from which the promised suffering proceeds. In fact our God, the lover of virtue, does not commit evil.

O marvellous clemency that is not comprehended! Which words would be enough to praise you? Which songs of thanksgiving could we sing to the mercy and goodness of God? He “removes from us our faults” (Ps. 102, 12) with that which follows. Look how Jonah, out of place and without reason, shows himself sad, while, as is fitting to a holy person, should have approved the action of God and exulted with joy. “You give yourself suffering” he says, on the contrary you show yourself indignant “for that castor oil plant that grew in a night and in a night perished, and I should not have pity on that great city, in which there are more than a hundred and twenty thousand people, who do not know how to distinguish between the right and the left hand?” (Jon. 4, 9. 10 – 11).

Children in fact do not know how to discern these things, for this it is right to be more benevolent with them who do not have faults: which sins can be attributed to the one who still does not know how to distinguish his own hands?

Then when he speaks of beasts of burden and says that you need to spare them, he shows also in this great goodness. The just one has

compassion on the life of the animals themselves, and this is a merit to him: what marvel is it, then, if the God of the universe forgives and has mercy on the just? In this way Christ has saved everyone giving himself as the price of redemption: for the humble and the great, for the wise and for the ignorant, for the rich and the poor, for the Jew and the Greek. It is right therefore that we proclaim: "Men and beasts you save, Lord. How precious is your grace, O God! Men take refuge in the shadow of your wings" (Ps. 35, 7. 8).

Responsorial.

R: Lord, I would be in anguish if I did not know your mercy; you have said: I do not take pleasure in the death of the wicked, but that he stops from his evil conduct and lives. * You who have called the Canaanite and the publican to conversion.

V: and you welcomed Peter in tears, O merciful Lord!

R: You who have called the Canaanite and the publican to conversion.

Gospel. Mt. 17: 22 – 27

They will kill him and he will rise again.

The sons are exempted from paying tribute.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

As they were gathering in Galilee, Jesus said to them, "The Son of man is to be delivered into the hands of men, and they will kill him, and he will be raised on the third day." And they were greatly distressed.

When they came to Caper'na-um, the collectors of the half-shekel tax went up to Peter and said, "Does not your teacher pay the tax?" He said, "Yes." And when he came home, Jesus spoke to him first, saying, "What do you think, Simon? From whom do kings of the earth take toll or tribute? From their sons or from others?" And when he said, "From others," Jesus said to him, "Then the sons are free. However, not to give offence to them, go to the sea and cast a hook, and take the first fish that comes up, and when you open its mouth you will find a shekel; take that and give it to them for me and for yourself."

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 6: 8 – 2*

Elisha captures his enemies in a miraculous way and mercifully frees them.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

Once when the king of Syria was warring against Israel, he took counsel with his servants, saying, "At such and such a place shall be my camp. But the man of God sent word to the king of Israel, "Beware that you do not pass this place, for the Syrians are going down there." And the king of Israel sent to the place of which the man of God told him. Thus he used to warn him, so that he saved himself there more than once or twice.

And the mind of the king of Syria was greatly troubled because of this thing; and he called his servants and said to them, "Will you not show me who of us is for the king of Israel?" And one of his servants said, "None, my lord, O king; but Eli'sha, the prophet who is in Israel, tells the king of Israel the words that you speak in your bedchamber." And he said, "Go and see where he is, that I may send and seize him." It was told him, "Behold, he is in Dothan."

So he sent there horses and chariots and a great army; and they came by night, and surrounded the city.

When the servant of the man of God rose early in the morning and went out, behold, an army with horses and chariots was round about the city. And the servant said, "Alas, my master! What shall we do?" He said, "Fear not, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them." Then Eli'sha prayed, and said, "O LORD, I pray you, open his eyes that he may see." So the LORD opened the eyes of the young man, and he saw; and behold, the mountain was full of horses and chariots of fire round about Eli'sha.

And when the Syrians came down against him, Eli'sha prayed to the LORD, and said, "Strike this people, I pray you, with blindness." So he struck them with blindness in accordance with the prayer of Eli'sha.

And Eli'sha said to them, "This is not the way, and this is not the city; follow me, and I will bring you to the man whom you seek." And he led them to Sama'ria. As soon as they entered Sama'ria, Eli'sha said, "O

LORD, open the eyes of these men, that they may see." So the LORD opened their eyes, and they saw; and lo, they were in the midst of Sama'ria.

When the king of Israel saw them he said to Eli'sha, "My father, shall I slay them? Shall I slay them?" He answered, "You shall not slay them. Would you slay those whom you have taken captive with your sword and with your bow? Set bread and water before them that they may eat and drink and go to their master." So he prepared for them a great feast; and when they had eaten and drunk, he sent them away, and they went to their master.

And the Syrians came no more on raids into the land of Israel.

Responsorial. *Lk. 6, 35. 36; 2 Kg. 6,22*

R: Love your enemies, do good without hoping for anything, * be merciful as your Father is merciful.

V: Do not kill. Instead place before them bread and water, so that they can eat and drink.

R: be merciful as your Father is merciful.

Second Reading. *Lett. 32, 23, 24, 25*

*Let us purify our senses from all types of impurity,
and the Lord Jesus Christ will voluntarily live in us.*

A reading from the "Letters" of St. Paulinus of Nola, bishop.

Let us pray to the Lord because, while we build externally for him the visible temple, He constructs in us that invisible "dwelling that is not constructed by men's hands"(2 Cor. 5,1), in which we know that we will enter at the end of time, when we will see face to face that which we now see as in a mirror and know in an imperfect way (cfr. 1 Cor. 13, 12).

But now, while we find ourselves in the tabernacle of this body almost under the skins of that ancient tabernacle, in the desert and under the tents, that is in the vast loneliness of this world, the Word of God shadowed in the column of cloud precedes us, in order to protect our head on the day of struggle; or in the column of fire, so that we may come to know on earth his way that leads to heaven (Cfr. Ex. 13, 22; Ps. 139, 8; Ps. 66, 3). Let us pray therefore that through these tabernacles of the Church we may arrive to the house of God, where the same Lord resides as the elevated stone, detached

from the mountain and contemporarily grown on the mountain: “a marvellous work of the Lord in our eyes” (Ps. 117, 23).

He Himself now offers himself for our construction as the foundation and culmination, because He is the beginning and the end. And in constructing we see what things of our fragile and earthly substance is worthy of being placed on the divine foundation, so that, vivified by the same corner stone, we may become useful stones in the construction of the heavenly temple. Let us melt in Christ the gold of our sentiments and the silver of our word. He who scrutinises the souls that are pleasing to Him, after having purified us in the furnace of this world, will render us into enflamed gold and coins that are worthy of bearing the impression of His image. On our part let us offer to Him those stones, rendered precious by the works of light.

Let us not be hard of heart like wood, or sterile in works like dry hay, or unstable in faith and in charity, weak and inconsistent like chaff. On the contrary, so that the commitment of our will does not reveal itself to be quickly consumed, but develops itself with firmness in peace. We invoke for our edification that profound peace in which the temple is built, so that “no noise of hammer or pickaxe or of any other implement of iron is heard” (1 Kg. 6, 7). Nor does the intervention of the enemy impede or interrupt the new construction, as it happened during the reparation of the temple itself, because of the envious hostility of the Persians.

We will become in fact a house of prayer and peace, on the condition that no worries of carnal thoughts surprises us, and that no agitation of the world disturbs our interior calm. It is therefore a good thing that the Lord visits the temple of our heart often, once it is built, bringing the whip of fear, through which he throws out of us the tables of the money-changers and the sellers of bulls and doves, so that our souls would not exercise the commerce of avarice and in our senses we would not penetrate the laziness of the bulls; and neither would it come to us to sell our innocence or the same grace of God, or to make of the house of prayer a den of thieves. Then when we have purified our senses of every ferment of iniquity, our Lord Jesus Christ will walk voluntarily.

Responsorial. *1 Pt. 2, 4. 5; Act 4, 11*

R: Setting yourselves close to Him, the living stone, * you also will be used as a living stone for the construction of a spiritual building, for a holy

priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices pleasing to God, through Jesus Christ.

V: This is the stone that has become the corner stone.

R: You also will be used as a living stone for the construction of a spiritual building, for a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices pleasing to God through Jesus Christ.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Zc. 9: 1 – 10:2*

Promise of salvation for Sion.

A reading from the prophet Zechariah.

An Oracle The word of the LORD is against the land of Hadrach and will rest upon Damascus. For to the LORD belong the cities of Aram, even as all the tribes of Israel; Hamath also, which borders thereon, Tyre and Sidon, though they are very wise. Tyre has built herself a rampart, and heaped up silver like dust, and gold like the dirt of the streets. But lo, the Lord will strip her of her possessions and hurl her wealth into the sea, and she shall be devoured by fire. Ash'kelon shall see it, and be afraid; Gaza too, and shall writhe in anguish; Ekron also, because its hopes are confounded. The king shall perish from Gaza; Ash'kelon shall be uninhabited; a mongrel people shall dwell in Ashdod; and I will make an end of the pride of Philistia.

I will take away its blood from its mouth, and its abominations from between its teeth; it too shall be a remnant for our God; it shall be like a clan in Judah, and Ekron shall be like the Jeb'usites. Then I will encamp at my house as a guard, so that none shall march to and fro; no oppressor shall again overrun them, for now I see with my own eyes. Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion! Shout aloud, O daughter of Jerusalem! Lo, your king comes to you; triumphant and victorious is he, humble and riding on an ass, on a colt the foal of an ass.

I will cut off the chariot from E'phraim and the war horse from Jerusalem; and the battle bow shall be cut off, and he shall command peace to the nations; his dominion shall be from sea to sea, and from the River to

the ends of the earth. As for you also, because of the blood of my covenant with you, I will set your captives free from the waterless pit. Return to your stronghold, O prisoners of hope; today I declare that I will restore to you double. For I have bent Judah as my bow; I have made E'phraim its arrow. I will brandish your sons, O Zion, over your sons, O Greece, and wield you like a warrior's sword. Then the LORD will appear over them, and his arrow go forth like lightning; the Lord GOD will sound the trumpet, and march forth in the whirlwinds of the south. The LORD of hosts will protect them, and they shall devour and tread down the slingers; and they shall drink their blood like wine, and be full like a bowl, drenched like the corners of the altar. On that day the LORD their God will save them for they are the flock of his people; for like the jewels of a crown they shall shine on his land.

Yes, how good and how fair it shall be! Grain shall make the young men flourish, and new wine the maidens. Ask rain from the LORD in the season of the spring rain, from the LORD who makes the storm clouds, who gives men showers of rain, to every one the vegetation in the field. For the teraphim utter nonsense and the diviners see lies; the dreamers tell false dreams, and give empty consolation. Therefore the people wander like sheep; they are afflicted for want of a shepherd.

Responsorial. *Zec. 9, 9; Jn. 12, 14*

R: Behold, your king comes to you, just and victorious; humble, he rides on a donkey, a colt the foal of a donkey. * Exult greatly, daughter of Sion; rejoice, daughter of Jerusalem.

V: Jesus found a young donkey and mounted it, as it is written:

R: exult greatly, daughter of Sion; rejoice, daughter of Jerusalem.

Second Reading. *Disc. 9 on the Palms.*

Behold to you comes your king, just and saviour.

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Andrew of Crete, bishop.

Let us join in the words of the gospel and say to Christ: “Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord, the King of Israel.” Let us wave before him like palm branches his dying words on the cross. Let us greet him, not with olive branches, but with the good deeds of mercy shown to one another. Let us strew beneath his feet like garments the desires of our

hearts, that he may walk in us and dwell wholly in us, that he may reveal us whole in himself and himself whole in us. Let us greet Sion with the words of the prophet: “Rejoice, O daughter of Sion, do not fear; Lo, your king comes to you, gentle, and riding on an ass, the foal of an ass.”

He is coming, he who is present in every place and fills all things, that in you he may bring about the salvation of all men. He is coming, who came not to call the righteous but sinners to repentance, that he may recall those wandering in sin. Therefore do not be afraid: “God is in the midst of you, you will not be moved.”

Receive in your upturned hands the God who adorned your walls and set them in his own hands. Receive him who laid your foundations in the palm of his hands. Receive him who took upon himself all our nature apart from sin to pay all our debts from his treasures. Rejoice, city of Sion, our mother, do not be afraid. Keep your feasts. Glorify for his mercy him who has come to us in you. Rejoice very greatly, daughter of Jerusalem and dance. “Arise, shine”—we greet you with the sound of the sacred trumpet, as Isaiah said—“for your light has come, and the glory of the Lord has risen upon you.”

What is that light? Was it not the light which enlightens every man who comes into the world, the eternal light, I mean, the timeless light revealed in time, the light revealed in the flesh and hidden by nature, the light which shone around the shepherds and led the Wise Men on their way? It was the light that was in the world from the beginning, through which the world was made, and yet the world knew it not. It was the light that came to its own home and its own people received it not.

What does “the glory of the Lord” mean? For sure it is the cross on which Christ was glorified, Christ the brightness of the Fathers glory, as he himself said when he came to his passion: “Now is the Son of man glorified, and in him God is glorified, and God will glorify him at once”, meaning here by “glory” his being lifted up on the cross. The glory of Christ is the cross and his being lifted up, for he says: “And I, when I am lifted up, will draw all men to myself.”

Responsorial. *Ps. 117, 26. 27. 23*

R: Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord; * God, the Lord, is our light.

V: Behold the work of the Lord: a marvel in our eyes.

R: God, the Lord, is our light.

Gospel. Mt. 18: 1 – 5, 10, 12 – 14

Take care not to despise even one of these little ones.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

At that time the disciples came to Jesus, saying, "Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?" And calling to him a child, he put him in the midst of them, and said, "Truly, I say to you, unless you turn and become like children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven. Whoever humbles himself like this child, he is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven. "Whoever receives one such child in my name receives me;

"See that you do not despise one of these little ones; for I tell you that in heaven their angels always behold the face of my Father who is in heaven."

What do you think? If a man has a hundred sheep, and one of them has gone astray, does he not leave the ninety-nine on the mountains and go in search of the one that went astray? And if he finds it, truly, I say to you, he rejoices over it more than over the ninety-nine that never went astray. So it is not the will of my Father who is in heaven that one of these little ones should perish.

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 6: 24 – 25, 32 – 7:16*

Samaria is miraculously liberated from the siege.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

Afterward Ben-ha'dad king of Syria mustered his entire army, and went up, and besieged Samaria. And there was a great famine in Samaria, as they besieged it, until an ass's head was sold for eighty shekels of silver, and the fourth part of a kab of dove's dung for five shekels of silver. Eli'sha was sitting in his house, and the elders were sitting with him. Now the king had dispatched a man from his presence; but before the messenger arrived Eli'sha said to the elders, "Do you see how this murderer has sent to take off my head? Look, when the messenger comes, shut the door, and hold the door fast against him. Is not the sound of his master's feet behind him?"

And while he was still speaking with them, the king came down to him and said, "This trouble is from the LORD! Why should I wait for the LORD any longer?" But Eli'sha said, "Hear the word of the LORD: thus says the LORD, 'Tomorrow about this time a measure of fine meal shall be sold for a shekel, and two measures of barley for a shekel, at the gate of Samaria.' Then the captain on whose hand the king leaned said to the man of God, "If the LORD himself should make windows in heaven, could this thing be?" But he said, "You shall see it with your own eyes, but you shall not eat of it."

Now there were four men who were lepers at the entrance to the gate; and they said to one another, "Why do we sit here till we die? If we say, 'Let us enter the city,' the famine is in the city, and we shall die there; and if we sit here, we die also. So now come, let us go over to the camp of the Syrians; if they spare our lives we shall live, and if they kill us we shall but die." So they arose at twilight to go to the camp of the Syrians; but when they came to the edge of the camp of the Syrians, behold, there was no one there. For the Lord had made the army of the Syrians hear the sound of chariots, and of horses, the sound of a great army, so that they said to one another, "Behold, the king of Israel has hired against us the kings of the Hittites and the kings of Egypt to come upon us." So they fled away in the

twilight and forsook their tents, their horses, and their asses, leaving the camp as it was, and fled for their lives. And when these lepers came to the edge of the camp, they went into a tent, and ate and drank, and they carried off silver and gold and clothing, and went and hid them; then they came back, and entered another tent, and carried off things from it, and went and hid them. Then they said to one another, "We are not doing right. This day is a day of good news; if we are silent and wait until the morning light, punishment will overtake us; now therefore come, let us go and tell the king's household." So they came and called to the gatekeepers of the city, and told them, "We came to the camp of the Syrians, and behold, there was no one to be seen or heard there, nothing but the horses tied, and the asses tied, and the tents as they were." Then the gatekeepers called out, and it was told within the king's household.

And the king rose in the night, and said to his servants, "I will tell you what the Syrians have prepared against us. They know that we are hungry; therefore they have gone out of the camp to hide themselves in the open country, thinking, 'When they come out of the city, we shall take them alive and get into the city.'" And one of his servants said, "Let some men take five of the remaining horses, seeing that those who are left here will fare like the whole multitude of Israel that have already perished; let us send and see." So they took two mounted men, and the king sent them after the army of the Syrians, saying, "Go and see." So they went after them as far as the Jordan; and, lo, all the way was littered with garments and equipment which the Syrians had thrown away in their haste. And the messengers returned, and told the king.

Then the people went out, and plundered the camp of the Syrians. So a measure of fine meal was sold for a shekel, and two measures of barley for a shekel, according to the word of the LORD.

Responsorial. *2 Kg. 7, 2; Mk. 11, 23*

R: The equerry of the king answered Elisha: Could a similar thing be true? He answered him: * You will see it with your own eyes.

V: He who does not doubt in his heart, believing that what he asks will happen, it will be done for him.

R: You will see it with your own eyes.

Second Reading. *Disc. 2 for the dedication 1, 2, 3*

Decorate your talamum, Sion, because the Lord has put in you His pleasure.

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Bernard, Abbot.

Once the glorious king and prophet of the Lord, the holy David, started to be moved by a religious solicitation, considering it as unworthy that the Lord of hosts did not as yet have a dwelling on earth, while he lived in a house worthy of a king. Even we, brothers, have to seriously think of this and take decisively a resolution. In fact, even though the Lord was pleased with the decision of the prophet, yet the realisation was reserved for Solomon.

Even you, O soul, live in a sublime dwelling that has been prepared for you by the Lord. Blessed, highly blessed, the soul that can say: “We know that when this body, our dwelling on the earth, will be destroyed, we will receive a dwelling from God, an eternal dwelling, not constructed by man’s hands, in heaven” (2 Cor. 5,1). Therefore do not concede sleep to your eyes, O soul, or rest to your eyelids, until you find a seat for the Lord, a dwelling for the Powerful one of Jacob. (cfr. Ps. 131, 4-5).

What do you think, brothers? Where can we find the place of this dwelling, and who can be the architect? The visible temple has been made to receive us; but the Most High does not live in a dwelling constructed by the hands of man. What temple can we therefore construct for him who said: “Do I not fill the heavens and the earth? Word of the Lord” (Jer. 23, 24). I would be in deep anguish and my spirit would languish if I did not hear the Lord Himself affirm: My Father and I “will come to him and take up a dwelling in him” (Jn. 14, 23). Now finally I know where I can prepare a dwelling for Him, because only he who is His image can contain Him. Capable of Him is the soul, really created in his image. For this hurry, adorn your talamum, O Sion, “Because the Lord is pleased with you and your land will have a bridegroom” (Is. 62, 4). “Exult greatly, daughter of Sion” (Zec. 9, 9); your God is coming to dwell in you. For this, my brothers, with all the desire of the heart and with a worthy thanksgiving, let us dedicate ourselves to building in us a temple for the Lord. Request urgently above all that He lives in us and then in all together, so that he may not repel from Himself neither the single nor the multitudes. **Each one above all should be careful not to be divided inside, because “every kingdom divided in itself will fall**

into ruin" (Lk. 11, 17), nor will the Christ enter where there are falling walls and enclosures that are falling.

Responsorial. *Lev. 26, 11. 12; 2 Cor. 6, 16*

R: I will establish my dwelling in the midst of you and I will not repel you.

* I will walk in the midst of you, I will be your God and you will be my people.

V: We are the temple of the living God, as God Himself has said:

R: I will walk in the midst of you, I will be your God and you will be my people

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Zec. 10: 3 – 11:3*

Liberation and return of Israel.

A reading from the prophet Zechariah.

Thus says the Lord: "My anger is hot against the shepherds, and I will punish the leaders; for the LORD of hosts cares for his flock, the house of Judah, and will make them like his proud steed in battle. Out of them shall come the cornerstone, out of them the tent peg, out of them the battle bow, out of them every ruler. Together they shall be like mighty men in battle, trampling the foe in the mud of the streets; they shall fight because the LORD is with them, and they shall confound the riders on horses. "I will strengthen the house of Judah, and I will save the house of Joseph. I will bring them back because I have compassion on them, and they shall be as though I had not rejected them; for I am the LORD their God and I will answer them.

Then E'phraim shall become like a mighty warrior, and their hearts shall be glad as with wine. Their children shall see it and rejoice, their hearts shall exult in the LORD. "I will signal for them and gather them in, for I have redeemed them, and they shall be as many as of old. Though I scattered them among the nations, yet in far countries they shall remember me, and with their children they shall live and return.

I will bring them home from the land of Egypt, and gather them from Assyria; and I will bring them to the land of Gilead and to Lebanon, till

there is no room for them. They shall pass through the sea of Egypt, and the waves of the sea shall be smitten, and all the depths of the Nile dried up.

The pride of Assyria shall be laid low, and the sceptre of Egypt shall depart. I will make them strong in the LORD and they shall glory in his name," says the LORD.

Open your doors, O Lebanon, that the fire may devour your cedars! Wail, O cypress, for the cedar has fallen, for the glorious trees are ruined!

Wail, oaks of Bashan, for the thick forest has been felled! Hark, the wail of the shepherds, for their glory is despoiled! Hark, the roar of the lions, for the jungle of the Jordan is laid waste!

Responsorial. *Cfr. Zec. 10, 6; Is. 28, 5*

R: I will render them victorious and I will lead them back to their country, because I have had mercy on them, I the Lord their God: * and their hearts will exult in the Lord.

V: In that day the Lord of the universe will be a crown of glory and a splendid diadem for the remnant of His people;

R: and their hearts will exult in the Lord.

Second Reading. *Disc. 21: 1 – 4*

The heart of the just will exult in the Lord.

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Augustine, bishop.

“The just will rejoice in the Lord and he will place all his hope in Him, and the upright of heart will draw glory from Him” (Ps. 63, 11). This we have sung not only with the voice but also with the heart. These words have been addressed to God by the Christian conscience and tongue. “The just will rejoice” not in the world, but “in the Lord”. “A light has been raised for the just” it says elsewhere, “joy for the upright of heart” (Ps 96, 11). Perhaps you want to ask from where this joy comes. Listen: “the just will rejoice in the Lord” and elsewhere “Search for the joy in the Lord, He will fulfil the desires of your hearts” (Ps. 36, 4).

What are we ordered and what is given to us? What are we commanded and what is lavished upon us? That we may rejoice in the Lord! But who rejoices in what he does not see? Or perhaps we see the Lord? This is only the object of the promise. Now instead “we walk in faith and until we live in the body we are in exile, far away from the Lord” (2 Cor. 5, 7. 6). In

faith and not in vision. When in vision? When what John himself says will be fulfilled: “Dearest, until now we are children of God, but what we will be has not yet been revealed. We know however that when He will be manifested, we will be similar to Him, because we will see Him as He is.” (1 Jn. 3,2).

Then there will follow great and perfect happiness, then there will be complete joy, where there will no longer be the hope to sustain us, but the reality itself to satisfy us. Yet even now, before this reality arrives to us, before we reach the reality itself, let us rejoice in the Lord. In fact it does not bear little joy that hope to which follows the reality.

Now therefore let us live in hope. It is for this that the Scripture says: “The just will rejoice in the Lord” and immediately afterwards, because they do not yet see the reality, it adds: “and places all his hope in Him”.

We have above all the first fruits of the Spirit and perhaps already something more. In fact already now we are near to the one whom we love. Already now we are given a taste and a foretaste of that food and that drink, of which one day we will be avidly satisfied.

But how can we rejoice in the Lord, if He is so far away from us? Far away? No. He is not far away that is if you yourself do not force Him to go far away from you. Love Him and you will feel Him close. Love Him and He will come to live in you.

“The Lord is close: do not distress yourself for nothing” (Ph. 4, 5-6). Do you want to see how He is near to you, if you love Him? “God is love” (1 Jn. 4,8)

But you want to ask me: What is love? Love is the virtue by which we love. What do we love? An ineffable good, a beneficial good, a good that creates all goods. He himself will be your delight, because from Him you will receive all that causes your delight. He is certainly not speaking of sin. In fact only sin you do not receive from Him. Except for sin, you have from Him all the other things that you possess.

Responsorial.

R: Before contemplating that which you cannot see, believe that which you do not see. * Walk in faith, and you will reach the vision.

V: You will not be blessed in the homeland because of the vision, if on the way the faith has not comforted you.

R: Walk in faith, and you will reach the vision.

Gospel. Mt. 18: 15 – 20

If he listens to you, you will have gained a brother.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

“If your brother sins against you, go and tell him his fault, between you and him alone. If he listens to you, you have gained your brother. But if he does not listen, take one or two others along with you, that every word may be confirmed by the evidence of two or three witnesses. If he refuses to listen to them, tell it to the church; and if he refuses to listen even to the church, let him be to you as a Gentile and a tax collector. Truly, I say to you, whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven. Again I say to you, if two of you agree on earth about anything they ask, it will be done for them by my Father in heaven. For where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I in the midst of them.”

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 9: 1 – 16, 22 – 27*

Jehu is made king of Israel by a disciple of Elisha.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

Then Eli'sha the prophet called one of the sons of the prophets and said to him, "Gird up your loins, and take this flask of oil in your hand, and go to Ramoth-gilead. And when you arrive, look there for Jehu the son of Jehosh'aphat, son of Nimshi; and go in and bid him rise from among his fellows, and lead him to an inner chamber. Then take the flask of oil, and pour it on his head, and say, 'Thus says the LORD, I anoint you king over Israel.' Then open the door and flee; do not tarry." So the young man, the prophet, went to Ramoth-gilead. And when he came, behold, the commanders of the army were in council; and he said, "I have an errand to you, O commander." And Jehu said, "To which of us all?" And he said, "To you, O commander." So he arose, and went into the house; and the young man poured the oil on his head, saying to him, "Thus says the LORD the God of Israel, I anoint you king over the people of the LORD, over Israel. And you shall strike down the house of Ahab your master that I may avenge on Jez'ebel the blood of my servants the prophets, and the blood of all the servants of the LORD. For the whole house of Ahab shall perish; and I will cut off from Ahab every male, bond or free, in Israel. And I will make the house of Ahab like the house of Jerobo'am the son of Nebat, and like the house of Ba'asha the son of Ahi'jah. And the dogs shall eat Jez'ebel in the territory of Jezreel, and none shall bury her." Then he opened the door, and fled.

When Jehu came out to the servants of his master, they said to him, "Is all well? Why did this mad fellow come to you?" And he said to them, "You know the fellow and his talk." And they said, "That is not true; tell us now." And he said, "Thus and so he spoke to me, saying, 'Thus says the LORD, I anoint you king over Israel.'" Then in haste every man of them took his garment, and put it under him on the bare steps, and they blew the trumpet, and proclaimed, "Jehu is king."

Thus Jehu the son of Jehosh'aphat the son of Nimshi conspired against Joram. (Now Joram with all Israel had been on guard at Ramoth-gilead against Haz'ael king of Syria; but King Joram had returned to be healed in Jezreel of the wounds which the Syrians had given him, when he fought with Haz'ael king of Syria.) So Jehu said, "If this is your mind, then let no one slip out of the city to go and tell the news in Jezreel." Then Jehu mounted his chariot, and went to Jezreel, for Joram lay there. And Ahazi'ah king of Judah had come down to visit Joram.

And when Joram saw Jehu, he said, "Is it peace, Jehu?" He answered, "What peace can there be, so long as the harlotries and the sorceries of your mother Jez'ebel are so many?" Then Joram reined about and fled, saying to Ahazi'ah, "Treachery, O Ahazi'ah!" And Jehu drew his bow with his full strength, and shot Joram between the shoulders, so that the arrow pierced his heart, and he sank in his chariot. Jehu said to Bidkar his aide, "Take him up, and cast him on the plot of ground belonging to Naboth the Jezreelite; for remember, when you and I rode side by side behind Ahab his father, how the LORD uttered this oracle against him: 'As surely as I saw yesterday the blood of Naboth and the blood of his sons -- says the LORD - I will requite you on this plot of ground.' Now therefore take him up and cast him on the plot of ground, in accordance with the word of the LORD." When Ahazi'ah the king of Judah saw this, he fled in the direction of Beth-haggan. And Jehu pursued him, and said, "Shoot him also"; and they shot him in the chariot at the ascent of Gur, which is by Ibleam. And he fled to Megid'do, and died there.

Responsorial. 2 kg. 9, 13. 12; Lk. 19, 36. 38

R: All of them hurriedly took their garments and laid it out under him, they sounded the trumpets and cried out: Jehu is king! * The Lord said: I anoint you king over Israel.

V: And as He advanced, they lay their cloaks on the road saying: Blessed is He who comes, the king, in the name of the Lord.

R: The Lord said: I anoint you king over Israel.

Second Reading. Hom. 20

He who glories, should glory in the Lord.

A reading from the "Homilies" of St. Basil the Great, bishop.

Let the wise man not glory in his wisdom, let not the mighty man glory in his might, let not the rich man glory in his riches.

But what constitutes true boasting, and wherein is a man great? 'Let him who glories glory in this', it is written, 'that he understands and knows me, that I am the Lord'.

Herein lies the greatness of man, his glory and his majesty, truly to know what is great, to cling to it, and to seek glory from the Lord of glory. For the Apostle says, 'Let him who boasts, boast of the Lord', in the passage where he writes, 'God made Christ our wisdom, our righteousness and sanctification and redemption; therefore, as it is written, let him who boasts, boast of the Lord'.

A man glories fully and perfectly in God when he does not extol himself on account of his own righteousness, but knows that he is lacking in true righteousness, and that he is really justified by faith alone in Christ.

Paul boasts of the fact that he despises his own righteousness, but seeks that righteousness by faith which comes through Christ, which comes from God, so that he may know him and the power of his resurrection, and may share his sufferings, becoming like him in his death, that if possible he may somehow attain the resurrection from the dead.

Here all loftiness of pride has fallen. Nothing of which you may boast is left you, O man, so let your boast and your hope be founded on him, so that you mortify all that is yours, and seek your future life in Christ. Since we have the first fruits of this, we are already enjoying it, living totally in the grace and free gift of God.

It is God who is at work with you both to will and to work for his good pleasure. What is more, through his Spirit, God reveals his wisdom, which he predestined for our glorification.

God gives us strength and energy in our toils. 'I worked harder than any of them', says St. Paul, 'though it was not I, but the grace of God which is with me'.

God has freed us from dangers beyond all human hope. 'We felt', he says again, 'that we had received the sentence of death, but that was to make us rely not on ourselves, but on God who raises the dead; he delivered us from so deadly a peril and he delivers us now. On him we have set our hope that he will deliver us again.'

Responsorial. *Cfr. Ws. 15, 3; Jn. 17, 3*

R: To know you, O God, is perfect justice, * to know your power is the root of immortal life.

V: This is eternal life: that we know you, the only true God and he whom you have sent, Jesus Christ.

R: to know your power is the root of immortal life.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Zec. 11: 4- 12:8*

Parable of the shepherds.

A reading from the prophet Zechariah.

Thus said the LORD my God: "Become shepherd of the flock doomed to slaughter. Those who buy them slay them and go unpunished; and those who sell them say, 'Blessed be the LORD, I have become rich'; and their own shepherds have no pity on them. For I will no longer have pity on the inhabitants of this land, says the LORD. Lo, I will cause men to fall each into the hand of his shepherd, and each into the hand of his king; and they shall crush the earth, and I will deliver none from their hand.

"So I became the shepherd of the flock doomed to be slain for those who trafficked in the sheep. And I took two staffs; one I named Grace, the other I named Union. And I tended the sheep. In one month I destroyed the three shepherds. But I became impatient with them, and they also detested me. So I said, "I will not be your shepherd. What is to die, let it die; what is to be destroyed, let it be destroyed; and let those that are left devour the flesh of one another." And I took my staff Grace, and I broke it, annulling the covenant that I had made with all the peoples. So it was annulled on that day, and the traffickers in the sheep, who were watching me, knew that it was the word of the LORD. Then I said to them, "If it seems right to you, give me my wages; but if not, keep them." And they weighed out as my wages thirty shekels of silver. Then the LORD said to me, "Cast it into the treasury" -- the lordly price at which I was paid off by them. So I took the thirty shekels of silver and cast them into the treasury in the house of the LORD. Then I broke my second staff Union, annulling the brotherhood between Judah and Israel. Then the LORD said to me, "Take once more the

implements of a worthless shepherd. For lo, I am raising up in the land a shepherd who does not care for the perishing, or seek the wandering, or heal the maimed, or nourish the sound, but devours the flesh of the fat ones, tearing off even their hoofs.

Woe to my worthless shepherd, who deserts the flock! May the sword smite his arm and his right eye! Let his arm be wholly withered, his right eye utterly blinded!"

An Oracle, the word of the LORD concerning Israel: Thus says the LORD, who stretched out the heavens and founded the earth and formed the spirit of man within him: "Lo, I am about to make Jerusalem a cup of reeling to all the peoples round about; it will be against Judah also in the siege against Jerusalem. On that day I will make Jerusalem a heavy stone for all the peoples; all who lift it shall grievously hurt themselves. And all the nations of the earth will come together against it. On that day, says the LORD, I will strike every horse with panic, and its rider with madness. But upon the house of Judah I will open my eyes, when I strike every horse of the peoples with blindness. Then the clans of Judah shall say to themselves, 'The inhabitants of Jerusalem have strength through the LORD of hosts, their God.' "On that day I will make the clans of Judah like a blazing pot in the midst of wood, like a flaming torch among sheaves; and they shall devour to the right and to the left all the peoples round about, while Jerusalem shall still be inhabited in its place, in Jerusalem. "And the LORD will give victory to the tents of Judah first, that the glory of the house of David and the glory of the inhabitants of Jerusalem may not be exalted over that of Judah. On that day the LORD will put a shield about the inhabitants of Jerusalem so that the feeblest among them on that day shall be like David, and the house of David shall be like God, like the angel of the LORD, at their head.

Responsorial. *Zec. 11, 12. 13; Mt. 26, 15*

R: They weighed out thirty shekels of silver as my wages: * a good sum, with which I have been valued by them.

V: Judas said: How much do you want to give me for handing him over to you? And they fixed thirty silver coins.

R: a good sum, with which I have been valued by them.

Second Reading. *C. 2*

Prayer to the good Shepherd.

A reading from the “Song of Songs” of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

Where do you pasture your flock, O good shepherd, you who take on your shoulders the whole flock, for the whole of human nature that you take on your shoulders forms one sheep? Show me the place of green pastures and the restful waters, lead me to the grass that nourishes, call me by name, so that I who am your sheep may hear your voice. Give me by your voice eternal life. Speak to me, you whom my soul loves.

This is how I name you, for your name is above every name and cannot be uttered or comprehended by any rational nature. Your name that reveals your goodness is the love my soul has for you. How can I not love you who loved me, even though I was black, so much that you laid down your life for the sheep whose shepherd you are? Greater love than this cannot be conceived, that you should purchase my salvation with your life.

Show me then, she says, where you pasture your flock that I may find the pasture of salvation and be satisfied with heavenly food, that food which a man must eat to enter into eternal life. I shall run to you, the fountain, I shall drink the heavenly draught which you pour forth for those who thirst, pouring water out of your side like a fountain when the veins were opened with the spear. If any man tastes of this he becomes a spring of water welling up to eternal life.

If you feed me with these things you will make me lie down at noon, when, sleeping in peace, I shall rest in light that knows no shade. For everywhere at noon there is no shade when the sun shines over the peak upon which you make to lie down those whom you pasture, when you take your children with you into bed. None is thought worthy of this noonday rest unless he has become the son of light and of the day. He who has placed himself at an equal distance from the shadows of the dawn and of nightfall, that is from the beginning and the conclusion of evil, that man is made to lie down to rest at midday by the sun of righteousness.

Show me then, she says, how I must sleep and what is the way to the noontide rest, that I may not lose your good and guiding hand and be brought by ignorance of truth to join the flock of sheep who are strangers to your flock.

This she said when she was anxious about the beauty which she had been given by God, when she wished to learn how her loveliness might

remain forever.

Responsorial. *Ps. 26, 4. 13; Phil. 1, 21*

R: One thing I asked of the Lord, this only I seek: to live in the house of the Lord all the days of my life. * I am sure of contemplating the goodness of the Lord in the land of the living.

V: For me to live is Christ and to die a gain.

R: I am sure of contemplating the goodness of the Lord in the land of the living.

Gospel. *Mt. 18: 21 – 19:1*

I do not tell you to forgive seven times, but up to seventy times seven.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Then Peter came up and said to him, "Lord, how often shall my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? As many as seven times?" Jesus said to him, "I do not say to you seven times, but seventy times seven." Therefore the kingdom of heaven may be compared to a king who wished to settle accounts with his servants. When he began the reckoning, one was brought to him who owed him ten thousand talents; and as he could not pay, his lord ordered him to be sold, with his wife and children and all that he had, and payment to be made. So the servant fell on his knees, imploring him, 'Lord, have patience with me, and I will pay you everything.' And out of pity for him the lord of that servant released him and forgave him the debt.

But that same servant, as he went out, came upon one of his fellow servants who owed him a hundred denarii; and seizing him by the throat he said, 'Pay what you owe.' So his fellow servant fell down and besought him, 'Have patience with me, and I will pay you.' He refused and went and put him in prison till he should pay the debt. When his fellow servants saw what had taken place, they were greatly distressed, and they went and reported to their lord all that had taken place. Then his lord summoned him and said to him, 'You wicked servant! I forgave you all that debt because you besought me; and should not you have had mercy on your fellow servant, as I had mercy on you?' And in anger his lord delivered him to the jailers, till he should pay all his debt. So also my heavenly Father will do to every one of you, if you do not forgive your brother from your heart." Now

when Jesus had finished these sayings, he went away from Galilee and entered the region of Judea beyond the Jordan.

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 11: 1 –21*

Athaliah and king Joash.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

Now when Athali'ah the mother of Ahazi'ah saw that her son was dead, she arose and destroyed all the royal family. Jehosh'eba, the daughter of King Joram, sister of Ahazi'ah, took Jo'ash the son of Ahazi'ah, and stole him away from among the king's sons who were about to be slain, and she put him and his nurse in a bedchamber. Thus she hid him from Athali'ah, so that he was not slain; and he remained with her six years, hid in the house of the LORD, while Athali'ah reigned over the land.

But in the seventh year Jehoi'ada sent and brought the captains of the Carites and of the guards, and had them come to him in the house of the LORD; and he made a covenant with them and put them under oath in the house of the LORD, and he showed them the king's son. And he commanded them, "This is the thing that you shall do: one third of you, those who come off duty on the Sabbath and guard the king's house (another third being at the gate Sur and a third at the gate behind the guards), shall guard the palace; and the two divisions of you, which come on duty in force on the Sabbath and guard the house of the LORD, shall surround the king, each with his weapons in his hand; and whoever approaches the ranks is to be slain. Be with the king when he goes out and when he comes in." The captains did according to all that Jehoi'ada the priest commanded, and each brought his men who were to go off duty on the Sabbath, with those who were to come on duty on the Sabbath, and came to Jehoi'ada the priest.

And the priest delivered to the captains the spears and shields that had been King David's, which were in the house of the LORD; and the guards stood, every man with his weapons in his hand, from the south side of the house to the north side of the house, around the altar and the house. Then he brought out the king's son, and put the crown upon him, and gave him the testimony; and they proclaimed him king, and anointed him; and they clapped their hands, and said, "Long live the king!"

When Athali'ah heard the noise of the guard and of the people, she went into the house of the LORD to the people; and when she looked, there was the king standing by the pillar, according to the custom, and the captains and the trumpeters beside the king, and all the people of the land rejoicing and blowing trumpets. And Athali'ah rent her clothes, and cried, "Treason! Treason!"

Then Jehoi'ada the priest commanded the captains who were set over the army, "Bring her out between the ranks; and slay with the sword any one who follows her." For the priest said, "Let her not be slain in the house of the LORD." So they laid hands on her; and she went through the horses' entrance to the king's house, and there she was slain.

And Jehoi'ada made a covenant between the LORD and the king and people, that they should be the Lord's people; and also between the king and the people. Then all the people of the land went to the house of Ba'al, and tore it down; his altars and his images they broke in pieces, and they slew Mattan the priest of Ba'al before the altars.

And the priest posted watchmen over the house of the LORD. And he took the captains, the Carites, the guards, and all the people of the land; and they brought the king down from the house of the LORD, marching through the gate of the guards to the king's house. And he took his seat on the throne of the kings. So all the people of the land rejoiced; and the city was quiet after Athali'ah had been slain with the sword at the king's house. Jeho'ash was seven years old when he began to reign.

Responsorial. *2 Chr. 23, 3; Jer. 23, 5*

R: All the assembly concluded a covenant with the king in the temple of God, Jeho'iada said to them: Behold the son of the king. He has to rule, * as the Lord has promised to the sons of David.

V: Look the days will come in which I will raise up for David a just shoot, who will reign as true king and he will be wise,

R: as the Lord has promised to the sons of David.

Second Reading. Book 1

I have come so that they may have life.

A reading from the treatise “The life in Christ” of Nicholas Cabasilas.

If the types and figures bring us the happiness that is searched for, the truth and the reality itself are vain. The fact that through the death of Christ the enmity has been eradicated, and the dividing wall has been demolished, and the peace and justice have arisen in the times of the Saviour, in short all these facts of this type, what sense would they still have, if before this sacrifice men had been just and friends of God?

There are other arguments with regard to this. Then there was the law to unite them to God: now instead it is the faith, grace, and all that refers to it. It appears evident that at that time the communion of men with God consisted above all in a relationship of slavery, now instead it consists of an adoption as sons and of friendship. To the servants in fact a law is given, while grace, faith and trust belongs to the friends and children. From all this it is evident that the Saviour is the “first born from the dead”(Ap. 1,5), and that none of the dead could rise to immortal life before the Christ started to live as resurrected. In the same way, even with regard to holiness and justice, He alone preceded all men; Paul attests this when he says that the Christ entered into the Holy of Holies as our precursor (cfr. He.6, 20). In fact, He entered after He had offered Himself to the Father, and introduced those whom He wanted, that is all those whom He had rendered participants of His burial; the ones who certainly do not have to die like Him, but who participate spiritually in that death in the bath of baptism and, after having been anointed, announce Him in the sacred table, eating in an ineffable way of Him who died and was raised to life. And so, through this door, He introduces them into the kingdom in order to crown them.

These doors then are much more useful and worthy of veneration than those of the earthly paradise. Those in fact did not open to anyone who already had not entered before and could also throw out those who already found themselves inside; this instead, even though the first are closed receives only, without letting anyone go out again. Those could be closed, and so they remained; above these the veil has been completely torn and the wall of separation knocked down: it is not possible to rebuild the ruin or to reconstruct those doors, nor to divide again with a wall of separation the two worlds, the superior one and the inferior one. In fact the heavens have

not been simply opened, but enlarged and almost torn, as Mark says. It is therefore evident that neither doors, nor doorposts, nor any veils have remained.

He in fact who has reconciled and united the heavenly world with that of the earth, and has made peace destroying the wall of separation, cannot repudiate Himself, as the blessed Paul affirms. It was natural that those doors, opened for Adam so that he could remain, were closed as a consequence of his unfaithfulness. Christ Himself opened them, He who had not committed sin, nor would have committed it. “His justice, says David, lasts forever” (Ps. 110,3). For this it is necessary that it remains always open, in order to introduce to life, without letting anyone come out of the life. “I have come so that they may have life” (Jn. 10, 10), said the Saviour. This is the life that the Lord has brought with Himself; that appropriating ourselves of these mysteries, we may become participants and associates of the death and passion of the One without whom we cannot flee death. And as it is not possible to enter into life without baptism in the water and in the Holy Spirit, so also it is not possible for those who do not eat the flesh of the Son of man and drink His blood to have life in themselves.

Responsorial. *Gal. 2, 19. 20*

R: By means of the law I am dead to the law in order to live for God. * This life that I live in the flesh, I live in the faith of the Son of God, who has loved me and has given Himself for me.

V: I have been crucified with Christ and it is not anymore I who live, but Christ who lives in me.

R: This life that I live in the flesh, I live in the faith of the Son, who has loved me and has given Himself for me.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Zec. 12: 9 – 12a; 13: 1 – 9*

The salvation of Jerusalem.

A reading from the prophet Zechariah.

And on that day I will seek to destroy all the nations that come against Jerusalem. "And I will pour out on the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem a spirit of compassion and supplication, so that, when they look on him whom they have pierced, they shall mourn for him, as one mourns for an only child, and weep bitterly over him, as one weeps over a first-born. On that day the mourning in Jerusalem will be as great as the mourning for Hadadrim'mon in the plain of Megid'do. The land shall mourn, each family by itself; the family of the house of David by itself, and their wives by themselves; the family of the house of Nathan by itself, and their wives by themselves;

"On that day there shall be a fountain opened for the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem to cleanse them from sin and uncleanness." And on that day, says the LORD of hosts, I will cut off the names of the idols from the land, so that they shall be remembered no more; and also I will remove from the land the prophets and the unclean spirit. And if any one again appears as a prophet, his father and mother who bore him will say to him, 'You shall not live, for you speak lies in the name of the LORD'; and his father and mother who bore him shall pierce him through when he prophesies. On that day every prophet will be ashamed of his vision when he prophesies; he will not put on a hairy mantle in order to deceive, but he will say, 'I am no prophet, I am a tiller of the soil; for the land has been my possession since my youth.' And if one asks him, 'What are these wounds on your back?' he will say, 'The wounds I received in the house of my friends.'"

"Awake, O sword, against my shepherd, against the man who stands next to me," says the LORD of hosts.

"Strike the shepherd, that the sheep may be scattered; I will turn my hand against the little ones. In the whole land, says the LORD, two thirds shall be cut off and perish, and one third shall be left alive. And I will put this third into the fire, and refine them as one refines silver, and test them as gold is tested. They will call on my name, and I will answer them. I will say, 'They are my people'; and they will say, 'The LORD is my God.'"

Responsorial. 26, 31; *Zec.* 13, 7

R: All of you will be scandalised of me on this night. It is written in fact: * I will strike the shepherd and the sheep of the flock will be scattered.

V: Awake, O sword, against my shepherd, against him who is my companion. Oracle of the Lord.

R: I will strike the shepherd and the sheep of the flock will be scattered.

Second Reading. Part 3, 4

The mysteries of Christ and the life of the Church.

A reading from the treatise “The kingdom of Jesus” of St. John Eudes, presbyter.

We ought to imitate and complete in ourselves the various states and mysteries of Christ. We should frequently beseech him to bring them to perfection in us and in the whole Church.

For, though in his person they are perfected, the mysteries of Jesus have not yet reached completion in us, his members, nor in the Church, which is his mystical body. The Son of God plans to make us sharers in his mysteries, and, in a certain manner, continue them in us and in the Church by the graces which he has decided to communicate to us, and the effects which he wishes to bring about in us through these mysteries. This is how he wishes to complete his mysteries in us.

For this reason the apostle Paul can say that the whole Church, and that all of us are contributing to his being built up and arriving at full maturity.

This refers to his mystical age in his mystical body, and this age will complete its full span only on the day of judgement. In another text the same apostle says that by his physical sufferings he is completing what still remains of Christ’s sufferings.

So the Son of God decided to complete and fill up all his mysteries in us. When he is born again in our soul by the holy sacraments of baptism and the blessed Eucharist, and conforms to his likeness, he wishes to complete in us the mysteries of his incarnation, birth and hidden life. He makes it possible for us to live an interior spiritual life hidden with him in God. He intends to bring to perfection in us the mysteries of his passion,

death and resurrection by causing us to suffer, die and to rise with him and in him. Finally, he plans to complete his state of glorious immortality in us by bringing it about that we shall lead a glorious everlasting life with him and in him in heaven.

It is his will that his other states and mysteries are brought to perfection in us and in the Church; he wishes to make us sharers in them, and to continue them in us. They will not reach their completion until the end of the time that he has decreed, that is, until the end of the world.

Responsorial. *Col. 1, 24. 29*

R: I am happy with my sufferings, * I complete in my flesh that which is lacking in the sufferings of Christ, in favour of His body which is the Church.

V: I strive and fight, with the strength that comes from Him and which acts in me with power;

R: I complete in my flesh that which is lacking in the sufferings of Christ, in favour of His body which is the Church.

Gospel. *Mt. 19: 3 – 12*

Because of the hardness of your hearts Moses permitted you to repudiate your wives, but in the beginning it was not like this.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And Pharisees came up to him and tested him by asking, "Is it lawful to divorce one's wife for any cause?" He answered, "Have you not read that he who made them from the beginning made them male and female, and said, 'For this reason a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh'? So they are no longer two but one flesh. What therefore God has joined together, let not man put asunder."

They said to him, "Why then did Moses command one to give a certificate of divorce, and to put her away? He said to them, "For your hardness of heart Moses allowed you to divorce your wives, but from the beginning it was not so. And I say to you: whoever divorces his wife, except for fornication, and marries another, commits adultery."

The disciples said to him, "If such is the case of a man with his wife, it is not expedient to marry." But he said to them, "Not all men can receive

this saying, but only those to whom it is given. For there are eunuchs who have been so from birth, and there are eunuchs who have been made eunuchs by men, and there are eunuchs who have made themselves eunuchs for the sake of the kingdom of heaven. He who is able to receive this, let him receive it."

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading *2 Kings 13:10 – 25*

The reign of Joash in Israel. Death of the prophet Elisha

In the thirty-seventh year of Jo'ash king of Judah Jeho'ash the son of Jeho'ahaz began to reign over Israel in Sama'ria, and he reigned sixteen years. He also did what was evil in the sight of the LORD; he did not depart from all the sins of Jerobo'am the son of Nebat, which he made Israel to sin, but he walked in them.

Now the rest of the acts of Jo'ash, and all that he did, and the might with which he fought against Amazi'ah king of Judah, are they not written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Israel? So Jo'ash slept with his fathers, and Jerobo'am sat upon his throne; and Jo'ash was buried in Sama'ria with the kings of Israel.

Now when Eli'sha had fallen sick with the illness of which he was to die, Jo'ash king of Israel went down to him, and wept before him, crying, "My father, my father! The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!" And Eli'sha said to him, "Take a bow and arrows"; so he took a bow and arrows.

Then he said to the king of Israel, "Draw the bow"; and he drew it. And Eli'sha laid his hands upon the king's hands. And he said, "Open the window eastward"; and he opened it. Then Eli'sha said, "Shoot"; and he shot. And he said, "The Lord's arrow of victory, the arrow of victory over Syria! For you shall fight the Syrians in Aphek until you have made an end of them."

And he said, "Take the arrows"; and he took them. And he said to the king of Israel, "Strike the ground with them"; and he struck three times, and stopped. Then the man of God was angry with him, and said, "You should have struck five or six times; then you would have struck down Syria until you had made an end of it, but now you will strike down Syria only three times."

So Eli'sha died, and they buried him. Now bands of Moabites used to invade the land in the spring of the year. And as a man was being buried, lo, a marauding band was seen and the man was cast into the grave of

Eli'sha; and as soon as the man touched the bones of Eli'sha, he revived, and stood on his feet.

Now Haz'ael king of Syria oppressed Israel all the days of Jeho'ahaz. But the LORD was gracious to them and had compassion on them, and he turned toward them, because of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and would not destroy them; nor has he cast them from his presence until now. When Haz'ael king of Syria died, Ben-ha'dad his son became king in his stead.

Then Jeho'ash the son of Jeho'ahaz took again from Ben-ha'dad the son of Haz'ael the cities which he had taken from Jeho'ahaz his father in war. Three times Jo'ash defeated him and recovered the cities of Israel.

Responsorial *2 Kings 13:14; Mt 23:34*

R: Elisha became sick with the sickness of which he died; Jo'ash king of Israel, came down to visit him, he burst into tears in front of him and said: * My father, my father, chariot of Israel and his cavalry!

V: Look, I will send prophets, wise men and scribes, and of these some they will kill and crucify.

R: My father, my father, chariot of Israel and his cavalry

Second Reading

There was a man sent by God

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Aelred, Abbot

Elijah was the model of hermetic life in the Old Testament, in the new instead it is St. John the Baptist, he who comes with the strength and spirit of Elijah. It seems to me then that, as John came with the strength and the spirit of Elijah, so also Elijah preceded John in spirit and in virtue. That is that Elijah is referred to according to the letter, and John is referred to according to the spirit.

Know well, brothers, as Elijah, while the time of the famine had already arrived, began his ministry in the act of speaking to Ahab, as the scripture says: “Elijah the Tishbite, one of the inhabitants of Galaad, said to Ahab” (1 Kg. 17, 1). Without putting before hand anything about his genealogy, about his type of life, about his religion, the Scripture introduces him in an unforeseen and inspired way, almost as if it did not come from a man or by means of a man, but as it is written also of our Elijah: “A man

came sent by God and his name was John” (Jn. 1, 6). And when did this happen? While Ahab and the evil Jezabel, his wife, reigned. It is for this reason that during their reign the famine dominated over the earth, the rain ceased to fall, the frost did not fall anymore and everything was dried up. For this Elijah could say: By the life of the Lord, in whose presence I am standing, in these years there will be neither dew nor rain, until I will say so” (1 Kg. 17, 1).

Do not ignore, my dearest, how pride and lust were reigning in the world when the coming of the Saviour was already near, to the point that no one seemed to be free from the passion of the domination, almost no one alien from the corruption of lust. Justly therefore did the hunger spread, bread was lacking and water could not be found anymore. When did all this happen? Precisely with the appearance of our Elijah. The law and the prophets in fact arrived up to John.

The law, the bread, the prophetic doctrine, the water. Up to the coming of John in fact the law maintains all its vigour and the doctrine of the prophets was listened to. But look the hunger and thirsts breaks in: “not hunger for bread nor thirst for water, but of listening to the word of God” (Am. 8, 11). Elijah flees far away from Ahab. John also flees far away and remains in the desert, as the evangelist says of him: “He lived in deserted regions until the day of his manifestation to Israel” (Lk. 1, 80). And it was necessary that it came about like this. Justly he who would have been constituted above peoples and kingdoms to tear up and to disperse, to destroy and to plant and to build, to reproach kings and to kill the prophets of the Baals, to obtain yet again the rain and dew for the earth, had to be first of all hidden in the most hidden recesses in order to be thus instructed in the reality of the spirit.

Responsorial *Mt 17:11-12; 11:13-14*

R: Elijah will come to re-establish everything. But I tell you: Elijah has already come * and they have not recognised him; on the contrary they have treated him as they wanted.

V: The Law and all the Prophets have prophesied up to John. And if you want to accept it, he is that Elijah who is to come.

R: and they have not recognised him; on the contrary they have treated him as they wanted.

CYCLE 2

First Reading *Zech 14:1–21*

Tribulations and glory of Jerusalem in the last times

Behold, a day of the LORD is coming, when the spoil taken from you will be divided in the midst of you. For I will gather all the nations against Jerusalem to battle, and the city shall be taken and the houses plundered and the women ravished; half of the city shall go into exile, but the rest of the people shall not be cut off from the city. Then the LORD will go forth and fight against those nations as when he fights on a day of battle. On that day his feet shall stand on the Mount of Olives which lies before Jerusalem on the east; and the Mount of Olives shall be split in two from east to west by a very wide valley; so that one half of the Mount shall withdraw northward, and the other half southward. And the valley of my mountains shall be stopped up, for the valley of the mountains shall touch the side of it; and you shall flee as you fled from the earthquake in the days of Uzzi'ah king of Judah. Then the LORD your God will come, and all the holy ones with him.

On that day there shall be neither cold nor frost. And there shall be continuous day (it is known to the LORD), not day and not night, for at evening time there shall be light. On that day living waters shall flow out from Jerusalem, half of them to the eastern sea and half of them to the western sea; it shall continue in summer as in winter. And the LORD will become king over all the earth; on that day the LORD will be one and his name one. The whole land shall be turned into a plain from Geba to Rimmon south of Jerusalem. But Jerusalem shall remain aloft upon its site from the Gate of Benjamin to the place of the former gate, to the Corner Gate, and from the Tower of Han'anel to the king's wine presses. And it shall be inhabited, for there shall be no more curse; Jerusalem shall dwell in security.

And this shall be the plague with which the LORD will smite all the peoples that wage war against Jerusalem: their flesh shall rot while they are still on their feet, their eyes shall rot in their sockets, and their tongues shall rot in their mouths. And on that day a great panic from the LORD shall fall on them, so that each will lay hold on the hand of his fellow, and the hand of the one will be raised against the hand of the other; even Judah will fight

against Jerusalem. And the wealth of all the nations round about shall be collected, gold, silver, and garments in great abundance. And a plague like this plague shall fall on the horses, the mules, the camels, the asses, and whatever beasts may be in those camps.

Then every one that survives of all the nations that have come against Jerusalem shall go up year after year to worship the King, the LORD of hosts, and to keep the feast of booths. And if any of the families of the earth do not go up to Jerusalem to worship the King, the LORD of hosts, there will be no rain upon them. And if the family of Egypt do not go up and present themselves, then upon them shall come the plague with which the LORD afflicts the nations that do not go up to keep the feast of booths. This shall be the punishment to Egypt and the punishment to all the nations that do not go up to keep the feast of booths. And on that day there shall be inscribed on the bells of the horses, "Holy to the LORD." And the pots in the house of the LORD shall be as the bowls before the altar; and every pot in Jerusalem and Judah shall be sacred to the LORD of hosts, so that all who sacrifice may come and take of them and boil the flesh of the sacrifice in them. And there shall no longer be a trader in the house of the LORD of hosts on that day.

Responsorial *Zech 13:1; Jn. 19:34*

R: In that day there will be for the house of David and for the inhabitants of Jerusalem * a gushing stream to wash away sin.

V: One of the soldiers pierced the side of Jesus with a lance and immediately there came out blood and water,

R: a gushing stream to wash away sin.

Second Reading *Op. Theo. 2*

I will be satisfied when your glory will appear

A reading from the “Conferences” of St. Thomas Aquinas, presbyter

It is fitting that the last article of faith in the creed should give expression to that which is the end of all our desires, namely eternal life, in the words, “Life everlasting, Amen.”

The first thing to be noted is that in eternal life man is united to God, since God himself is our reward and the end of all our labours: “I am your shield and your very great reward.” This union with God consists in seeing

him perfectly: “Now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face.” It consists in perfect praise. In the words of the prophet: “Joy and gladness will be found in her, thanksgiving and the voice of praise.”

Eternal life is the perfect fulfilment of desire; inasmuch as each of the blessed will have more than he desired or hoped for. The reason for this is that in this life no man can fulfil his desires, nor can any creature satisfy a man's craving; for God alone satisfies and infinitely surpasses man's desire, which for that reason is never at rest save in God. In the words of Augustine, “You have made us, O Lord, for yourself and our heart is restless until it rests in you.” And since in heaven the saints will possess God perfectly, it is evident that their desire will be satisfied and that their glory will surpass their expectation, hence our Lord said: “Enter into the joy of your Lord,” which Augustine explains by saying: “Their whole joy will not enter into the joyful, but the joyful will enter wholly into joy.”-“I shall be satisfied when your glory shall appear.” And again: “Who satisfies your desire with good,” because whatever is delightful will all be there superabundantly.

Thus if we desire pleasure, there will be supreme and most perfect delight, in that its object will be God the sovereign good: “In your right hand is pleasure for evermore.”

Finally, eternal life consists in the joyful companionship of all the blessed, a companionship which is full of delight; since each one will possess all good things together with all the blessed, for they will all love one another as themselves, and therefore, will rejoice in one another's happiness as if it were their own, and consequently the joy and gladness of one will be as great as the joy of all.

Responsorial *cf. Ps 16:15; 1 Cor 13:12*

R: In my justice I will contemplate your face, Lord; * as I wake up I will be filled with your presence.

V: Now I know in an imperfect way, but then I will know perfectly, as also I have been known;

R: as I wake up I will be filled with your presence.

Gospel *Mt 19:13 – 15*

*Let the children come to me
Because it is to them that the kingdom of heaven belongs*

Then children were brought to Jesus that he might lay his hands on them and pray. The disciples rebuked the people; but Jesus said, "Let the children come to me, and do not hinder them; for to such belongs the kingdom of heaven." And he laid his hands on them and went away.